



CHANDRA FOODS · CHAAT GUIDE

Bhel Puri vs Sev Puri vs Pani Puri

What's the difference?

Bhel puri is tossed, sev puri is stacked, and pani puri is filled and dunked. That is the short answer. All three are chaat, all three use sev and the same two chutneys, and all three get mixed up on menus because the names sound alike. What separates them is the base: puffed rice for bhel puri, flat papdi for sev puri, and hollow shells for pani puri.

This guide compares the three side by side, gives a quick recipe for each, and shows how to build a **chaat snacks** UK spread at home from one shopping list.

THE TOSSED ONE

Bhel puri

Base: puffed rice
Eaten: from a bowl, with a spoon

THE STACKED ONE

Sev puri

Base: flat papdi
Eaten: by hand, piece by piece

THE ONE-BITE ONE

Pani puri

Base: hollow shells
Eaten: whole, filled and dunked

What Is Chaat?

Chaat is the family name for Indian street food snacks that pile sour, sweet, spicy and salty into the same bite. The word comes from the Hindi chaatna, meaning "to lick". It covers dozens of dishes, and bhel puri, sev puri and pani puri are the three most people meet first.

They are among the most popular **Indian snacks** because they share a short list of building blocks: something crisp, boiled potato, onion, a sweet tamarind chutney, a green coriander-mint chutney, and sev. Change the crisp base and the method, and you get a different dish.

Bhel Puri: The Tossed One

Bhel puri is the Mumbai beach snack, sold in paper cones along Chowpatty and Juhu. Puffed rice is tossed with potato, onion, tomato, both chutneys and sev, then eaten straight away.

Because nothing is assembled piece by piece, it is the easiest of the three to make and the hardest to get wrong.

QUICK BHEL PURI (SERVES 4)

100g puffed rice

2 medium boiled potatoes, diced

1 small red onion and 1 tomato, finely chopped

3 tbsp tamarind chutney

2 tbsp green chutney

50g sev, plus extra on top

Chopped coriander and a squeeze of lemon

METHOD

Put everything except the sev in a large bowl, toss for 20 seconds, add the sev, toss once more and serve. Eat it within 15 minutes, before the puffed rice goes soft. If you want to skip weighing out the dry ingredients, a ready **bhel puri mix** gives you the crunchy base in one bag.

Sev Puri: The Stacked One

Sev puri swaps the bowl for a plate. Each flat papdi gets a little potato, onion and tomato, a few drops of each chutney, and then enough sev to hide everything underneath. The name is literal: puri covered in sev.

The whole dish depends on the base. Use a thin, crisp flat **chaat papdi**, because anything thick or slightly stale turns chewy the moment chutney touches it.

QUICK SEV PURI (SERVES 4)

24 flat papdi

2 medium boiled potatoes, roughly
mashed1 small red onion and 1 tomato, finely
chopped

Tamarind chutney and green chutney

60g fine sev

Chaat masala and chopped coriander

METHOD

Lay the papdi out on a plate. Top each with potato, onion and tomato, add the chutneys, then cover with sev and a pinch of chaat masala. Serve immediately. Fine **nylon sev** is the classic choice because it sits lightly and does not overpower the papdi.

Pani Puri: The One-Bite One

Pani puri uses a small hollow shell, called golgappa in the north and phuchka in Bengal. You crack the top, add spiced potato and chickpeas, fill it with chilled mint and tamarind water, and eat it whole.

It takes longest because the pani needs blending and chilling, but there is no frying if you start with ready-made **pani puri shells**. Blend mint, coriander and green chilli, stir into cold water with tamarind, black salt, roasted cumin and chaat masala, strain, and chill for two hours. Fill and dunk each shell only when someone is ready to eat it.

What About Dahi Puri and Papdi Chaat?

Two more names turn up next to these three, and both are yoghurt-based.

- **Dahi puri** uses the same hollow shells as pani puri. Instead of spiced water, each shell is filled with potato, sweetened yoghurt, both chutneys and sev.
- **Papdi chaat** uses the same flat papdi as sev puri, broken or whole, topped with potato, chickpeas, yoghurt, chutneys and sev. It is eaten with a spoon.

So if a search for papdi chaat near me or dahi puri near me turns up nothing close, the ingredients you already have for sev puri and pani puri will make both. Add a tub of yoghurt and you are there. A **papdi chaat kit** is the simplest way to get the papdi side sorted in one order.

One Shopping List for All Three

Most of the list is shared, which is why making all three is not much harder than making one.

SHARED ACROSS EVERY DISH

- Boiled potatoes
- Red onion, tomato, fresh coriander
- Tamarind chutney and green chutney
- Sev
- Chaat masala

THE ONE THING THAT CHANGES

- **Bhel puri:** puffed rice
- **Sev puri and papdi chaat:** flat papdi
- **Pani puri and dahi puri:** hollow puri shells, plus mint, black salt and tamarind for the pani

For a party, the Ultimate Chaat Party Combo saves ordering each crisp base separately. **Papdi** also works as a papdi snack on its own, so nothing goes to waste if you over-order.

Which One Should You Make First?

- **New to chaat:** start with bhel puri. No assembly, and it is ready in five minutes.
- **Having people over:** sev puri. It looks impressive on a platter and can be built in batches of ten.
- **Want the full street food experience:** pani puri. Set out the shells, filling and pani and let everyone make their own.

If you are feeding six or more, make all three. Boil the potatoes and make the chutneys once, then set out the three bases with a few Indian savoury snacks on the side.

Tips That Apply to All Three

- **Assemble at the last minute.** Chutney and pani soften everything within minutes.
- **Season the potato.** A pinch of salt, chaat masala and roasted cumin in the potato lifts all three dishes.
- **Balance the chutneys.** Tamarind gives sweetness and tang, green chutney gives heat. Use roughly three parts tamarind to two parts green and adjust from there.
- **Keep the crisp things sealed.** Puffed rice, papdi, sev and shells all go stale quickly once open. Store them in airtight tubs at room temperature.
- **Revive soft puffed rice.** Dry-toast it in a pan for two minutes and let it cool before using.

Frequently Asked Questions

What is the difference between bhel puri and sev puri?

Bhel puri is puffed rice tossed with vegetables, chutneys and sev in a bowl. Sev puri is built on individual flat papdi, each topped with potato, onion, chutneys and a layer of sev. One is mixed and eaten with a spoon, the other is assembled and eaten by hand.

Is pani puri the same as golgappa?

Yes. Golgappa, phuchka and pani puri are regional names for the same snack of hollow shells filled with potato and spiced water.

Is sev puri the same as papdi chaat?

No. Both use flat papdi, but sev puri is a dry topping of potato, chutneys and sev eaten by hand, while papdi chaat adds yoghurt and chickpeas and is eaten with a spoon.

Which is healthier, bhel puri or sev puri?

Bhel puri is generally the lighter choice, because puffed rice is not fried and the dish carries more raw vegetables. Sev puri sits on fried papdi with more sev. Portion size and the amount of sweet chutney matter more than the dish itself.

Are bhel puri, sev puri and pani puri vegetarian?

The traditional versions of all three are vegetarian. They are usually vegan too, as long as no yoghurt is added. Check individual product labels for allergens.

Can I use the same chutneys for all three?

Yes. Tamarind chutney and green coriander-mint chutney work across bhel puri, sev puri, pani puri, dahi puri and papdi chaat.

Where can I buy chaat ingredients in the UK?

Indian grocers carry most of them, and Chandra Foods sells sev, papdi, bhel puri mix and pani puri shells online with UK delivery, as well as from its store in Park Royal, London.

How long does bhel puri stay crisp?

About 15 minutes after mixing. Keep the puffed rice, sev and wet ingredients separate until you are ready to serve.

Build your chaat spread

Order sev, papdi, bhel puri mix and pani puri shells from Chandra Foods, made in the UK since 1985. Shop [Indian snacks online](#).